

Church Discipline

prc-church-discipline

Church Discipline · Discipline Process · practice · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible

Subject named directly in

Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Church discipline follows the Matthew 18 progression (private confrontation, small-group confrontation, assembly confrontation, removal) and is exercised in love for repentance and restoration.

In plain language

The proposition makes two claims the Greek and Hebrew text let us check separately. First, that confrontation moves through ordered stages. Matthew 18:15 opens with an actual command word, 'reprove him' (elegcho), the same verb the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) uses in Leviticus 19:17, 'you shall surely reprove your neighbor' (Hebrew yakach), where reproof sits inside the law of loving your neighbor. From there Matthew builds a ladder out of 'if-then' clauses (ean clauses, the conditional form). If he does not listen privately, take one or two others (duo, 'two'). If he still refuses, tell the assembly or church (ekklesia). If he refuses even the assembly, treat him as an outsider. Each rung is triggered only when the previous one fails, so the sequence is genuinely graduated, not a menu of equal options. First Corinthians 5 carries out the final rung with a direct command, 'remove the wicked person' (exairo), a verb that appears only once in the entire New Testament (a hapax) but openly quotes the Old Testament 'purge the evil from your midst' formula, and adds 'not to associate' (sunanamignumi) or even eat with an unrepentant member. Second Thessalonians 3 uses the same withdrawal verb (sunanamignumi) for the disorderly. Second, the proposition says discipline is done in love for repentance and restoration, and the words say this plainly and often. Matthew calls the goal 'gaining your brother' (adelphos). First Corinthians 5 says the severe step is so the person 'may be saved in the end' (the salvation 'in order that' purpose clause, the hina clause). Galatians 6:1 commands 'restoring such a one gently' (katartizo), using a mending word. Second Thessalonians 3:15 says 'do not treat him as an enemy but admonish him as a brother' (noutheteo, adelphos), and the word 'brother' (adelphos) keeps being used for the disciplined person. Second Corinthians 2 completes the cycle, telling the assembly to forgive, comfort, and 'reaffirm their love' (kuroo) so the restored person is not crushed by sorrow. The one place the words leave less detail is the exact extent of removal, because that command verb (exairo) occurs only once, but its Old Testament source still fixes the meaning. Across law, Gospel, and four letters the same shape repeats, with no manuscript variation disturbing either the ordered steps or the restoring purpose, so on the lexical evidence both halves of the claim hold together.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H3198	יָכַח	yakach	to rebuke	56
G0080	ἀδελφός	adelphos	brother	361
G0191	ἀκούω	akouo	to hear	452
G1417	δύο	duo	two	140

G1437	ἐάν	ean	if	374
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklesia	assembly	119
G1651	ἐλέγχω	elegcho	to rebuke	17
G1808	ἐξαίρω	exairo	to expel	1
G2219	ζύμη	zume	leaven	13
G2675	καταρτίζω	katartizo	to complete	13
G2919	κρίνω	krino	to judge	117
G2964	κυρόω	kuroō	to affirm	
G3560	νουθετέω	noutheteo	to admonish	8
G3868	παραίτεομαι	paraiteomai	to refuse/excuse	12
G3870	παρακαλέω	parakaleō	to plead/comfort	
G4205	πόρνος	pornos	sexual sinner	11
G4874	συναναμίγνυμι	sunanamignumi	to associate with	3

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The corrective process is carried by an actual command verb, 'reprove, convict' (elegcho), in the form of a completed past action used as a command (the aorist imperative 'reprove him', elegxon) at Matthew 18:15. This verb appears 17 times across the Gospels, the letters of Paul, the Pastoral letters, the General epistles, and Revelation, and is rooted in the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) translation of Leviticus 19:17 (Hebrew 'reprove', yakach), so the reproof command is spread across the whole Bible (pan-canonical). Matthew 18:15-17 then builds a graduated ladder through repeated 'if-then' clauses (conditional protases) of the form 'if he does not listen' (ean me akouse), widening from privacy to two or three witnesses to 'tell the assembly' (eipe te ekklesia, where 'assembly' or 'church' is ekklesia), to treating the unrepentant as an outsider. 1 Corinthians 5:13 enacts removal with the command 'remove' (the imperative exarate), a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament (a hapax), which directly quotes the recurring Deuteronomic 'purge the evil from your midst' formula (Deuteronomy 17:7 and parallels), and the assembly 'judges' (krinete, from krino) insiders. The restorative aim is lexically explicit: 'mend, restore' (katartizo) at Galatians 6:1, 'admonish as a brother' (noutheteo) at 2 Thessalonians 3:15, the salvation purpose clause at 1 Corinthians 5:5, and the 'reaffirm love' command 'ratify' (kuroo) at 2 Corinthians 2:8. Both halves of the proposition, ordered confrontation and restorative aim, are grounded in dense recurring vocabulary, so it is affirmed.

Scripture

Matt.18.15 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1651 ἐλέγχω, G1437 ἐάν, G0191 ἀκούω, G0080 ἀδελφός

Reasoning. The corrective process is named by a command verb. The 'reprove him' command (the aorist imperative elegxon, where aorist means a completed past action used here as a command) gives the action. The locative phrase 'between you and him alone' (metaxu sou kai autou monou) limits step one to private confrontation. The 'if-then' clause (the conditional 'if he listens to you', ean sou akouse, using the verb 'hear, listen' akouo) sets the success condition that ends the matter at 'you have gained your brother' (ekerdesas ton adelphon sou, where 'brother' is adelphos). The aim word is gain, not punishment, and 'reprove' (elegcho) is the same verb the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) uses at Leviticus 19:17.

Matt.18.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1417 δύο, G1437 ἐάν, G0191 ἀκούω

Reasoning. The second step widens the circle conditionally. The 'if' clause (the protasis 'but if he does not listen', ean de me akouse, using 'if' ean and 'hear' akouo) triggers 'take with you one or two more' (paralabe meta sou eti hena e duo, where 'two' is duo). The purpose clause cites the Deuteronomic 'on the word of two or three witnesses' (epi stomatos duo marturon e trion). The escalation is explicitly conditioned on prior failure, establishing a graduated sequence rather than parallel options.

Matt.18.17 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1437 ἐάν, G0191 ἀκούω, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. The third and fourth steps complete the ladder. A further 'if' clause (the conditional 'if he refuses to listen to them', ean de parakouse auton, using 'if' ean) escalates to 'tell the assembly or church' (eipe te ekklesia, where 'assembly or church' is ekklesia), naming the assembly or church (ekklesia) as the disciplining body. A final 'if' clause (ean de kai tes ekklesias parakouse, 'if he refuses even to listen to the assembly') yields 'let him be to you as the outsider and tax collector' (esto soi hosper ho ethnikos kai ho telones). The repeated 'if-then' chain (conditional chain) is the lexical backbone of the four-stage progression.

Lev.19.17 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3198 נָחַם,

Reasoning. The Old Testament root of corrective reproof. The infinitive absolute plus finite verb construction 'you shall surely reprove your neighbor' (hokeach tokiach et amitecha, from the Hebrew 'reprove' yakach) places reproof inside the love command of the holiness code, set against 'you shall not hate your brother' (lo tisna et achicha). The Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) renders the Hebrew 'reprove' (yakach) with 'reprove' (elegcho), the very verb commanded at Matthew 18:15, so the corrective process is anchored in the law and is not a New Testament novelty.

1Cor.5.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω, G1808 ἐξάιρω

Reasoning. The terminal removal step is enacted. The 'remove' command (the imperative exarate ton poneron ex humon auton, 'remove the wicked person from among you'), where 'remove' (exairo) is a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament (a hapax), directly quotes the recurring Deuteronomic 'purge the evil' formula. The phrase 'you judge those inside' (tous eso humeis krinete, where 'judge' is krino) distinguishes internal accountability from outsiders. This matches the Matthew 18 endpoint where the unrepentant is treated as outside the community.

1Cor.5.6 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2219 ζύμη

Reasoning. The rationale for removal is given through a leaven figure. The metaphor 'a little leaven leavens the whole lump' (mikra zume holon to phurama zumoi, where 'leaven' is zume) frames unaddressed sin as spreading corruption, supplying the protective and corporate purpose of discipline rather than vindictiveness.

1Cor.5.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4874 συναναμίγνυμι, G4205 πόρνος

Reasoning. The social form of removal is specified. The phrases 'not to associate' (me sunanamignusthai, from 'associate with, mix together' sunanamignumi) and 'not even to eat with such a one' (to toiouto mede sunesthiein) define the boundary placed on an unrepentant member named as a brother, paralleling the outsider language of Matthew 18:17. The list of grounds includes 'sexually immoral person' (pornos).

1Cor.5.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω

Reasoning. The severest action is framed by a salvation purpose. The phrase 'deliver such a one to Satan for the destruction of the flesh' (paradounai ton toiouton to Satana eis olethron tes sarkos) is governed by the 'in order that' purpose clause (the hina clause 'that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord', hina to pneuma sothe en te hemera tou kuriou), so even handing over has a restorative end stated in the grammar.

2Cor.2.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3870 παρακαλέω

Reasoning. Discipline is shown closing in restoration. After the 'punishment' (epitimia) of 2 Corinthians 2:6, the verbs 'forgive' (charisasthai) and 'comfort, urge' (parakalesai), with the warning lest such a one be swallowed by excessive sorrow, command the assembly to receive the now-repentant person back. The cycle from removal to reinstatement makes the restorative aim explicit in apostolic practice.

2Cor.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2964 κυρώω

Reasoning. The restoration is sealed by a command to love. The phrase 'reaffirm your love for him' (kurosai eis auton agapen) uses 'ratify, confirm' (kuroo), a ratifying verb, with 'love' (agape), directing the body to formally confirm love toward the restored member. This is the strongest single lexical proof that the disciplinary process aims at recovery, not mere expulsion.

2Thess.3.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4874 συναναμίγνυμι

Reasoning. The same withdrawal verb recurs. The phrase 'do not associate with him, that he may be ashamed' (me sunanamignusthai auto, hina entrape, where 'associate' is sunanamignumi) ties the disciplinary distance to a corrective and not destructive goal, the verb 'shame' (entrepo) signaling intended shame leading to change.

2Thess.3.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3560 νοουθετέω, G0080 ἀδελφός

Reasoning. The disposition of discipline is stated directly. The phrase 'yet do not regard him as an enemy, but admonish him as a brother' (kai me hos echthron hegeisthe alla noutheteite hos adelphon) uses 'admonish' (noutheteo), a verb of corrective instruction, and the persistent label 'brother' (adelphos) shows the disciplined person is still treated as family, making the restorative and loving aim explicit.

Gal.6.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2675 καταρτίζω, G0080 ἀδελφός

Reasoning. The restorative manner is lexically anchored. The command 'restore such a one in a spirit of gentleness' (katartizete ton toiouton en pneumatī prautetōs) uses 'mend, restore' (katartizo), a mending and setting-right verb used elsewhere of mending nets and being made complete, with 'gentleness' (prautēs). The reflexive guard 'watching yourself' (skopon seauton) guards against harshness. This directly supports the 'in love for repentance and restoration' clause of the proposition, the addressed person remaining a 'brother' (adelphos).

Titus.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3868 παραιτέομαι

Reasoning. A second graduated micro-sequence appears for the divisive person. The command 'after a first and second admonition, reject a factious person' (hairetikon anthropon meta mian kai deuteran nouthesian paraitou) gives two warnings, built on 'admonition' (nouthesia, the noun cognate of the verb 'admonish' noutheteo), before the command 'have nothing more to do with' (the imperative paraitou, from 'refuse, reject' paraiteomai), echoing the patient escalation of Matthew 18 on a smaller scale.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.18.15	Lev.19.17	openbible	45
Matt.18.15	Gal.6.1	openbible	32
Matt.18.15	Luke.17.3	openbible	30
Matt.18.15	2Thess.3.15	openbible	28
Matt.18.17	2Thess.3.6	openbible	12
Matt.18.17	1Cor.5.9	openbible	9
Matt.18.17	2Cor.2.6	openbible	3
1Cor.5.13	Deut.17.7	openbible	21
1Cor.5.13	Matt.18.17	openbible	11
Gal.6.1	2Cor.2.7	openbible	27
Gal.6.1	Ezek.34.16	openbible	24
Titus.3.10	Rom.16.17	openbible	26

Complicating texts

1Cor.5.5 · addressed

The phrase 'deliver such a one to Satan for the destruction of the flesh' (paradounai ton toiouton to Satana eis olethron tes sarkos) can read as purely punitive, but the 'in order that' purpose clause (the hina clause 'that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord', hina to pneuma sothe en te hemera tou kuriou) names salvation as the goal, keeping even the severest action within the restorative frame the proposition asserts.

Matt.18.17 · addressed

The phrase 'as the outsider and tax collector' (hosper ho ethnikos kai ho telones) might be heard as final and unloving rejection, but it marks a change of standing rather than a closed door, since the same Gospel records Jesus eating with tax collectors and the parallel restoration commands in Galatians 6:1, 2 Thessalonians 3:15, and 2 Corinthians 2:7-8 show the community still seeks and reinstates the person, so the loving and restorative aim is preserved.

1Cor.5.13 · addressed

The removal command 'remove' (exarate, from exairo) is a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament (a hapax), so the verb alone supplies no other Greek context to calibrate the exact form and extent of removal. The sense is nonetheless secured two ways: the verse quotes the recurring Old Testament 'purge the evil' formula (Deuteronomy 17:7 and parallels), which fixes the meaning as decisive separation from the community, and the surrounding 'judge' (krino) and 'associate with' (sunanamignumi) language defines the act as withholding fellowship from an unrepentant member. The hapax (single-occurrence word) limits granularity, not the basic fact of commanded removal.

Concordance traversed

G1651, G0191, G1437, G1577, G1417, G2919, G1808, G4874, G2219, G4205, G2675, G3560, G3868, G0080, H3198

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method) variant units were supplied for these passages and the anchors fall outside the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John). The apparatus markers visible in the anchor verses, for example the bracketed 'against you' (eis se) in Matthew 18:15 and word-order notes in 1 Corinthians 5 and 2 Thessalonians 3, touch wording but none alter the 'reprove' (elegcho) command, the graduated-step 'if-then' chain (conditional chain), the removal command, or the restorative purpose clauses, so the verdict is variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

grammatico-historical: affirms · The command verb 'reprove' (elegcho) at Matthew 18:15, the repeated 'if-then' clauses (conditional protases) that build the four-stage ladder, the removal command 'remove' (exairo), from exairo) at 1 Corinthians 5:13, and the restoration verbs 'restore' (katartizo), 'admonish' (noutheteo), and 'ratify love' (kuroo) across Galatians 6, 2 Thessalonians 3, and 2 Corinthians 2 yield a graduated, restoration-aimed discipline pattern on the plain sense of the syntax.

redemptive-historical (law-to-gospel continuity): affirms · Reading the texts along the covenant arc, the corrective reproof commanded in the holiness code at Leviticus 19:17 (Hebrew 'reprove', yakach, rendered 'reprove' elegcho in the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint) and the Deuteronomic 'purge the evil' formula quoted at 1 Corinthians 5:13 carry forward into the assembly, so church discipline is the new-covenant form of an established Old Testament practice rather than a fresh institution. This lens reads the same data and likewise affirms.

restorative-primacy reading: affirms with emphasis on aim over mechanism · A reader who weights the goal clauses most heavily notes that 'gaining the brother' (Matthew 18:15, where 'brother' is adelphos), the salvation purpose (1 Corinthians 5:5), gentle restoring using 'mend, restore' (katartizo) at Galatians 6:1, 'admonishing as a brother' using 'admonish' (noutheteo) at 2 Thessalonians 3:15, and 'reaffirming love' using 'ratify' (kuroo) at 2 Corinthians 2:8 dominate the vocabulary, so they affirm corrective discipline while stressing that the lexical center of gravity is recovery, and that the removal step is the servant of restoration, not an end in itself. This is a difference of emphasis, not a contradicting verdict.

The verdict rests on the analogy of Scripture and on progressive revelation: the reproof command is rooted in Leviticus 19:17, the witness rule and 'purge the evil' formula in Deuteronomy, the graduated steps in Matthew 18, the terminal removal in 1 Corinthians 5, the withdrawal mechanic in 2 Thessalonians 3, and the explicit restorative disposition in Galatians 6:1, 2 Thessalonians 3:15, and 2 Corinthians 2:7-8. No covenantal-arc move overturns the plain-sense reading; it reinforces it. The competing lenses differ only in emphasis, all affirming.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Describe how the Old and New Testament texts on confronting a sinning member relate to one another regarding the sequence of steps, the aim of the confrontation, and the disposition of those carrying it out.

The stem packages a specific four-stage ordering (private, small-group, assembly, removal) plus a stated motive (in love for repentance and restoration) into one proposition, which presumes both the sequence and the motive before testing them. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but each component was checked independently against queried data: the command verb 'reprove' (elegcho) stands at Matthew 18:15, the four-stage 'if-then' chain (conditional chain) runs through Matthew 18:15-17 with 'assembly or church' (ekklesia) named at verse 17, removal by the single-occurrence New Testament word (the hapax) 'remove' (exairo) at 1 Corinthians 5:13, and the loving and restorative motive by 'mend, restore' (katartizo) at Galatians 6:1, 'admonish' (noutheteo) at 2 Thessalonians 3:15, the salvation 'in order that' purpose clause (the hina clause) at 1 Corinthians 5:5, and 'ratify love' (kuroo agapen) at 2 Corinthians 2:8. Affirms is unchanged from the prior file; the enrichment corrected the prior anchor set, which had under-recorded the actual command and removal verbs, and added the Old Testament root, but the verdict did not change.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Matt.18.15
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1651

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.5.13
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1808
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gal.6.1
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Cor.2.8
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Lev.19.17
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3198
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Matt.18.15
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.5.13

License audit

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Flags

ecm-shadow